

Horizon Line & Eye Level

The invisible line that controls everything

The horizon line is the most important construction element in perspective drawing. It represents the viewer's eye level and determines how every object in the scene is seen — from above, below, or straight on.

KEY CONCEPTS

Eye Level = Horizon

Your horizon line is always at your eye level, regardless of what's in the scene. Even if you're drawing a mountainous landscape with no visible horizon, the perspective math still works from the same invisible eye-level line.

Above & Below the Horizon

Objects above the horizon line are seen from below — you see their underside. Objects below the horizon are seen from above — you see their top. This is constant and universal. Use it to check your drawings for perspective errors.

Moving the Horizon

Placing the horizon line high in the composition emphasizes the foreground and ground plane (great for landscapes). Placing it low emphasizes the sky and height (great for architecture). Center horizon is neutral and static.

Multiple Eye Levels

In a single scene, there is only one eye level. All perspective lines must converge on the same horizon — they cannot have different eye levels. This is a common mistake: mixing perspectives from different heights.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw the same interior 3 times: horizon high, center, and low. Compare the mood.
2. Find 5 photos and identify the horizon/eye level in each. Draw the line.
3. Draw a street scene and deliberately place figures at different heights relative to the horizon.

FURTHER READING

■ CTRL+Paint – Eye Level

<https://www.ctrlpaint.com/videos/eye-level>

■ Proko – Horizon Line Explained